

4.2 Agency Revision Notes

Key Questions:

- What constitutes agency, and how is it related to personhood?
- Is moral agency a necessary condition for being considered a person?
- How do different philosophical traditions approach the concept of agency in relation to personhood?

Philosophers:

1. Immanuel Kant (1724-1804)

- **Viewpoint: Moral Agency and Autonomy**
- **Argument:** Kant argued that true personhood is defined by the capacity for moral agency, which involves the ability to act according to rational principles and moral laws. He believed that individuals are autonomous agents capable of making ethical decisions based on their rational will. For Kant, moral agency is essential to personhood, as it allows individuals to be held accountable for their actions.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics argue that Kant's strict criteria for moral agency may exclude certain beings, such as infants or individuals with cognitive impairments, raising questions about the inclusivity of his definition of personhood.

2. John Stuart Mill (1806-1873)

- **Viewpoint: Utilitarianism and Agency**
- **Argument:** Mill emphasized the importance of individual agency in the context of utilitarian ethics, which focuses on the consequences of actions for overall happiness. He argued that personhood involves the capacity to make choices that contribute to the greater good. For Mill, agency is linked to the ability to pursue one's own happiness while considering the well-being of others.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics of Mill's utilitarian approach argue that it can lead to the justification of actions that violate individual rights in the name of the greater good. This raises concerns about the moral implications of prioritizing collective happiness over individual agency.

3. Hannah Arendt (1906-1975)

- **Viewpoint: Action and Plurality**
- **Argument:** Arendt emphasized the significance of action in defining personhood. She argued that agency is not just about individual decision-making but also about the capacity to engage with others in a shared public space. For Arendt, true agency arises in the context of

plurality, where individuals act together and create meaning through their interactions.

- **Counter-Argument:** Critics may argue that Arendt's focus on collective action can overlook the importance of individual agency and the personal motivations that drive decision-making. They contend that her view may downplay the role of individual responsibility in moral actions.

4. Daniel Dennett (1942-Present)

- **Viewpoint: Intentionality and Agency**
- **Argument:** Dennett advocates for a functionalist approach to agency, suggesting that agency can be understood in terms of intentionality and the ability to make decisions based on beliefs and desires. He argues that personhood involves the capacity to engage in complex decision-making processes that reflect one's values and goals. For Dennett, agency is a key aspect of what it means to be a person.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics of Dennett's functionalism may argue that it risks reducing agency to mere computational processes, neglecting the subjective experience and emotional dimensions of decision-making. They contend that a complete understanding of agency must also account for the qualitative aspects of human experience.

Conclusion: The exploration of personhood and agency encompasses a variety of perspectives, including the moral framework of Kant, the utilitarian approach of Mill, the action-oriented view of Arendt, and the functionalist perspective of Dennett. Understanding these diverse viewpoints enriches our comprehension of the complexities surrounding agency and its relationship to personhood.